Strong 2C Opening Bid

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The 2♣ opening bid is a cornerstone of Standard American bidding. It is strong and artificial, and can be either balanced or unbalanced.

If balanced, 2C traditionally shows:

- 22-24 HCP, or
- 28+ HCP

This assumes that an immediate 3NT opening bid shows 25-27 HCP. Hence the gap between HCP ranges.

However, if you play some sort of Gambling 3NT, you must lump 25-27 balanced HCP into your 2C opening.

Either way, you can open 2C and plan to rebid some number of no-trumps depending on your strength.

If unbalanced, 2C shows:

- 14+ HCP and no less than "a trick short of game", according to the 2023 ACBL Convention Chart guidelines

"A trick short of game" means at least 9 playing tricks with a 5+ card major (i.e. one trick shy of making 4♥/♠), or at least 10 playing tricks with a 5+ card minor (i.e. one trick shy of making 5♣/♦). Some players relax this requirement to be 8 1/2 and 9 1/2 playing tricks, respectively.

Examples:

♠AKQ
♥AK6
♦A32
♣KT94

Holding 23 points, open 2♣ and plan to rebid 2NT.

♠AKQ987
♥AK6
♦A32
♣5

With 20 points and 9 tricks (6 spades, 2 hearts and 1 diamond), open 2♣ and plan to rebid 2♠.

♠5
♥KQJT

♦AK
♣AKT987

With 20 points and 10 tricks (5 clubs, 3 hearts and 2 diamonds), open 2♣ and plan to rebid 3♣.

♠AKQJ987
♥AKT
♦653
♣—

This hand "only" has 17 HCP, but is a trick short of game (7 spades, 2 hearts). Open 2♣ and plan to rebid 2♠.

Before the strong 2♣ bid was invented, all opening bids at the 2-level were strong two bids, natural and forcing. The benefit of the strong 2♣ bid is that it can be played in conjunction with weak two bids, which occur more frequently and preempt the opponents.

Responses to 2♣

The opening 2♣ bid is forcing. There are three popular approaches for responder's bids:

Approach	Meaning
2♦ "waiting"	This is the approach officially supported by the ACBL in their Standard American Yellow Card, so it is the main approach that I'll describe.
2♦ "waiting", and 2♥ as an immediate negative bid	In this approach, both 2♦ and 2♥ are conventional relays, but the latter shows only 0-3 points.
Control-showing responses	1 king = 1 control, and 1 ace = 2 controls. This is the most complex of the three approaches.

Let's go over these one by one...

2♦ "Waiting"

Playing this approach, the conventional responses to 2♣ are as follows.

Response	Meaning
2♦	0-7 points, artificial. This is called the "negative" or "waiting" response, because it usually expresses a weak hand. However, responder will occasionally have 8+ points but no good bid, such as with 4441 distribution.
2♥	8+ points and 5+ hearts.
2♠	8+ points and 5+ spades.
2NT	8+ points and a balanced hand.
3♣	8+ points and 5+ clubs.
3♦	8+ points and 5+ diamonds.

With the exception of the artificial 2♦, all other responses are natural and game-forcing.

Examples:

Opener	Responder
♠KQJ53	♠642
♥AK	♥QT3
♦AJT9	♦876
♣AQ	♣5432

2♣	2♦ [1]

1. Artificial, "negative" or "waiting". 0-7 points.

Opener	Responder
♠AQ9	♠KJT74
♥AK5	♥Q986
♦AJT9	♦72
♣KQ4	♣A5
2♣	2♠ [1]

1. 5+ spades, 8+ points. Game-forcing.

2♦ "Waiting", and 2♥ as the "Double Negative"

Same as above, except that a 2♦ response is 3-7 points (at least one king), whereas a 2♥ response is a "double negative", showing a very bad hand (0-3 points, and no king). Example:

Opener	Responder
♠AQ9	♠JT74
♥AK5	♥Q986
♦AJT9	♦72
♣KQ4	♣876
2♣	2♥ [1]

1. The double negative bid, showing 0-3 points. No aces, no kings.

Note this means that responder must bid 3♥ if holding a good hand with 5+ hearts.

Control-Showing Responses

Control-showing responses are completely different than the above two methods. One "control" = one king. Two "controls" = one ace or two kings. Using basic arithmetic, responder tallies his number of controls and bids thusly:

Response	Meaning
2♦	0 or 1 controls
2♥	2 controls
2♠	1 ace and 1 king (3 controls)
2NT	3 kings (3 controls)
3♣	4 controls

Opener's Rebids

After a 2♦ "Waiting" Response

After hearing a 2♦ reply, opener's suit rebids are natural and forcing for one round. Any no-trump rebids, however, are non-forcing.

Opener's Rebid	Meaning
2♥	17+ points and 5+ hearts.
2♠	17+ points and 5+ spades.
2NT	22-24 points and a balanced hand. Note that this assumes an opening 2NT bid of 20-21 points.
3♣	17+ points and 5+ clubs.
3♦	17+ points and 5+ diamonds.
3NT	25-27 points and a balanced hand.
4NT	28-30 points and a balanced hand. I have never seen this come up.
5NT	31-32 points and a balanced hand. Ditto!

The one hand pattern that doesn't fit into the above bids is 4441. It is recommended to treat it as a balanced hand, and bid no-trumps accordingly. For instance, rebid 2NT with a 4441 23-pointer such as:

♠AK93
♥KQJT
♦Q
♣AKJ5

After a Positive Suit Response

If responder makes a positive suit response (2♥/♠ or 3♣/♦, the partnership is committed to reaching a game contract. Opener's rebids are natural.

Opener's Rebid	Meaning
2NT	23-24 points and a balanced hand.
3NT	Over 3♣/♦, this shows 23-24 points and a balanced hand. Over 2♥/♠ (i.e. a jump rebid of 3NT), this shows 25-27 points and a balanced hand.
Any raise	Natural, 17+ points, 3+ card support.
Any new suit	Natural, 17+ points, 5+ cards.

After a Positive 2NT Response

If responder bids 2NT to show 8+ points and a balanced hand, then the partnership's no-trump response system is on: Stayman, Jacoby Transfers, etc. Opener must bid accordingly, as if responder is the one who opened no-trumps.

Examples:

Opener	Responder
♠KQJ5	♠A642
♥AKQ	♥J87
♦AJT9	♦87
♣K6	♣T752
2♣	2♦ [1]
2NT [2]	3♣ [3]
3♠	4♠

1. Artificial, "negative" or "waiting". 0-7 points.

2. 23-24 points, balanced. Non-forcing.
3. Stayman.

Opener	Responder
♠KQ5	♠A642
♥AKQ87	♥T5
♦AJ	♦Q75
♣KJ6	♣A752
2♣	2NT [1]
3♦ [2]	3♥
3NT	6NT

1. Natural, balanced, 8+ points.
2. Jacoby Transfer to hearts.

Responder's Second Bid

After Opener's No-Trump Rebid

If opener rebids no-trumps (e.g. 2NT), then the partnership's no-trump response system is on: Stayman, Jacoby Transfers, etc.

After Opener's Suit Rebid

As already stated, any suit bid by opener is forcing for one round. Responder can bid as follows.

- Single raise - natural, 3+ card support. This shows a supporting hand with slam interest, **even if responder's first bid was 2♦.**
- Double raise - natural, 3+ card support (frequently 4+). **This is a signoff if responder's first bid was 2♦.**

  With a good hand, it's better to bid "slowly" and save space for slam exploration. With a poor hand, it's less important to save space. Thus the distinction between single raises and double raises, which is based on the principle of "fast arrival".

  Examples:

Opener	Responder
♠KQ5	♠A642
♥AKQ87	♥T952
♦AJ	♦Q543
♣KJ6	♣5
2♣	2♦ [1]
2♥	3♥ [2]

1. Negative.
2. A maximum hand (at the top of the 0-7 range) with slam interest in hearts. In practice, 6♥ is a reasonable contract.

Opener	Responder
♠KQ5	♠T642
♥AKQ87	♥T952
♦AJ	♦Q543
♣KJ6	♣5
2♣	2♦ [1]
2♥	4♥ [2]

1. Negative.
2. A weak hand (at the bottom of the 0-7 range) with heart support but no slam interest.

- All other bids - these can be played in two different styles...
  - Natural. All of responder's rebids are natural. New suits show 5+ cards, and no-trump bids show balanced hands. This is simple and easy to remember.
  - **The "Second Negative".** Many players use a conventional second bid by responder to show a truly poor hand of 0-4 points. This is done by either bidding:
    - The "cheapest" (i.e. lowest-available) minor suit, in response to 2♥/♠ or 3♣
    - 3NT in response to opener's 3♦ rebid

    The "second negative" is rather intricate, so some examples are in order:

Opener	Responder
♠KQ5	♠T642
♥AKQ87	♥T3
♦AJ	♦Q543
♣KJ6	♣542
2♣	2♦ [1]
2♥	3♣ [2]

1. Waiting.
2. If agreeing to play second negative bids, then 3♣ is the cheapest minor, artificial and showing 0-4 points. If not playing second negative bids, responder would be forced to bid 2NT, natural.

Opener	Responder
♠KQ5	♠AT642
♥AKQ87	♥T3
♦AJ	♦Q53
♣KJ6	♣542
2♣	2♦ [1]
2♥	2♠ [2]
3NT	

1. Waiting.
2. Natural, 5+ spades. If agreeing to play second negative bids, then this shows 5-7 points. If not playing the second negative, then this shows 0-7 points, which is less helpful for opener.

In Competition

- If 2♣ is doubled, responder can redouble with 4+ good clubs, or simply make his conventional response.
- If 2♣ is overcalled, responder's bids are natural. Double is for penalty, new suits are natural, and no-trump bids promise a stopper in the enemy suit. There is no longer a negative 2♦ bid; responder simply passes with a bad hand.

External Articles

- Mike Lawrence. Bidding More to Show Less.

See also

- ACOL 2♣
  A strong, conventional opening bid showing a balanced 23 HCP or an unbalanced, game-forcing hand.
- Kokish Relay
  A conventional relay after a strong 2♣ opening and a negative 2♦ response.
- Responses to a Strong 2♣ Opening Bid
  A hybrid approach to responding to a strong 2♣ opener that includes both transfer bids and step responses.
- Strong Two Bid
  The Standard American method of using 2♦, 2♥, or 2♠ opening bids to show strong hands.
- Weak Two Bid
  The Standard American method of using 2♦, 2♥, or 2♠ opening bids to show a weak one-suited hand.